

National College of Ireland

Ethical Guidelines and Procedures for Research involving Human Participants



SEPTEMBER 2017

EXAMPLE OF ETHICS FORM FOR SCHOOL OF COMPUTING

Ethics Application Checklist

To be submitted alongside the ethics application.

Please complete the below checklist, ticking each item to confirm that it has been addressed.

1. I agree to obtain informed written consent from all human participants aged over 18 who are involved in this research (or if circulating digitally, I will ensure that informed consent is completed, and will have the participants indicate their informed consent by continuing with their study engagement).	X
2. I agree to obtain informed written consent from the parents of anyone aged under 18 in this research (or from the schools if appropriate), and informed written assent from those under 18 in this research.	☐
3. I include a letter of agreement from a clinically responsible individual agreeing to (where appropriate) help me recruit/provide clinical support in the event that participants become distressed/host the study data collection.	☐
4. I append a letter of agreement from an external institution or organisation agreeing to host the study.	☐
5. I agree to comply with NCI's Data Retention Policy.	x
6. I have appended a) information sheet, b) consent form/assent form, c) debriefing sheet.	X
7. I have provided details of how non-anonymised data will be stored, in a safe and encrypted manner.	X
8. I have included my contact details and those of my supervisor (where appropriate). I have only included my NCI email address and not included any personal contact information.	x
9. I have given sufficient details on the proposed study design, methodology, and data collection procedures, to allow a full ethical review, and I understand that my failure to give sufficient detail may result in a resubmission being required.	x
10. I understand that if I make changes to my study following ethical approval, it is my responsibility to seek an ethics amendment if the change merits ethical consideration.	x

National College of Ireland

Human Participants Ethical Review Application Form

All parts of the below form must be completed. However in certain cases where sections are not relevant to the proposed study, clearly mark NA in the box provided.

Part A: Title of Project and Contact Information

Name

Dr Simon Caton

Student Number (if applicable)**Email**

simon.caton@ncirl.ie

Status:

Undergraduate ☐

Postgraduate ☐

Staff ☒ X

Supervisor (if applicable)

N/A

Title of Research Project

Am I Who I Say I am? Unobtrusive Self-Representation and Personality Recognition on Facebook

Category into which the proposed research falls (see guidelines)

Research Category A ☒ X

Research Category B ☐

Research Category C ☐

Have you read the NCI Ethical Guidelines for Research with Human Participants?

Yes ☒ X

No ☐

Please indicate any other ethical guidelines or codes of conduct you have consulted

N/A

Has this research been submitted to any other research ethics committee?

Yes ☐

No ☒ X

If yes please provide details, and the outcomes of this process, if applicable:

N/A

Is this research supported by any form of research funding?

Yes ☐
No ☒ X

If yes please provide details, and indicate whether any restrictions exist on the freedom of the researcher to publish the results:

N/A

Part B: Research Proposal

Briefly outline the following information (not more than 200 words in any section).

Proposed starting date and duration of project

21st May 2015 – 19th September 2017

The rationale for the project

Across platforms like Facebook, LinkedIn, Twitter, and blogging services, users (sub) consciously represent themselves in a way which is appropriate for their intended audience. However, researchers have not yet adequately addressed controlling for self-representation, or the propensity to display socially responding characteristics or censor oneself in online fora, in online social networks. The trove of potential online social media data is vast, but the ability of researchers to identify ground truth, and thus to verify its authenticity, is low. This can result in misleading or wrong analyses. As such, researchers on these platforms risk working with 'gamified,' or socially responding personas that go beyond efforts to contain Common Method Biases (CMB) in research design. This leaves the open question of alignment of unobtrusively gathered online data and self-reported data. This work will focus on the alignment of survey methods with unobtrusive methods of gathering data from online social media.

The research aims and objectives

The research work aims to explore the relationship between offline and online personalities via survey responses and self-produced text such that, participant-influenced biases in publically sourced data can be mitigated.

The research design

To facilitate the study, over 500 Amazon Mechanical Turk (AMT) workers will complete psychometric surveys via a Facebook application. In use for personality is the Big Five Inventory, human flourishing and an online social media usage survey, modified to be used for Facebook. It is acknowledged that many psychometrics exist that could be indicative of self-representation, but the ones in use are thoroughly researched and have strong literature-based benchmarks, and thus are the most appropriate for this analysis.

AMT has proven a reliable platform for conducting online experiments with its representative population. AMT has also been found to be more representative of diversity than standard samples, and is similar to the standard Facebook population. An initial screening question based on the Instructional Manipulation Check will be employed in order to minimize 'click-through' behaviour in order to increase the reliability of the results. Workers who will complete in less than nine minutes will be excluded from the analysis, as well as those with unit or item non-responses, or otherwise incomplete items. Payments of US\$ 0.74 will be issued at the end of the survey, equating to 1 cent per question. Regardless of users' privacy settings allowing timeline extraction or not, workers will be paid with survey completion. The study will be launched over a 24-hour period to accommodate differences in time zones.

Participants' names and IDs are automatically one-way hashed for user privacy, with timeline, survey, and worker payment being tied to the hashed ID. A summarized privacy statement and informed consent document is presented on the entry page of the AMT HIT (Human Intelligence Task). A full privacy statement is available, detailing the uses of data and steps taken to guarantee privacy.

As participants complete the survey, a PHP-based Facebook application simultaneously accesses and hashes their unique Facebook ID, and via Facebook's Open Graph API (application programming interface) accesses participants' Facebook timelines for offline analysis. Workers will be given an option to opt out of the HIT at the stage where it linked to their Facebook profile or abandon the HIT at any other point. Privacy-aware users will be able to hide their activities from the app.

A Facebook popup screen details the types of data requested by the app. The app extracts only posts, i.e., status updates, participants made to their timelines. Other post types such as comments, shares, profile updates, etc. are excluded as they are not fully self-produced texts. While this type of constraint can create researcher bias by potentially culling messages from the list of retrieved posts, the project only considers the online presentation of self.

The research sample and sample size

Please indicate the sample size and your justification of this sample size. Describe the age range of participants, and whether they belong to medical groups (those currently receiving medical treatment, those not in remission from previous medical treatment, those recruited because of a previous medical condition, healthy controls recruited for a medical study) or clinical groups (those undergoing non-medical treatment such as counselling, psychoanalysis, in treatment centres, rehabilitation centres, or similar, or those with a DSM disorder diagnosis).

The survey will be available via a Facebook application to AMT workers that are over the age of 18.

A target of at least 500 participants.

If the study involves a MEDICAL or CLINICAL group, the following details are required:

- a) Do you have approval from a hospital/medical/specialist ethics committee?
If YES, please append the letter of approval. Also required is a letter from a clinically responsible authority at the host institution, supporting the study, detailing the support mechanisms in place for individuals who may become distressed as a result of participating in the study, and the potential risk to participants.
If NO, please detail why this approval cannot or has not been sought.
- b) Does the study impact on participant's medical condition, wellbeing, or health?
If YES, please append a letter of approval from a specialist ethics committee.
If NO, please give a detailed explanation about why you do not expect there to be an impact on medical condition, wellbeing, or health.

The nature of any proposed pilot study. Pilot studies are usually required if a) a new intervention is being used, b) a new questionnaire, scale or item is being used, or c) established interventions or questionnaires, scales or items are being used on a new population. If no such study is planned, explain why it is not necessary.

N/A

The methods of data analysis. Give details here of the analytic process (e.g. the statistical procedures planned if quantitative, and the approach taken if qualitative. It is not sufficient to name the software to be used).

Text data from Facebook will be analysed with the LIWC sentiment analysis package.

Two statistical procedures are heavily utilized in this work, namely Spearman's ρ and Automatic Linear Modelling (SPSS version 22). In addition, a One-Way ANOVA will be performed to assess mean differences in one case.

Automatic Linear Modelling is employed for personality detection. The analysis will utilize the boosted, best-subset model consistent with data mining approaches as suggested in the literature.

Study Procedure

Please give as detailed an account as possible of a participant's likely experience in engaging with the study, from point of first learning about the study, to study completion. State how long project participation is likely to take, and whether participants will be offered breaks. Please attach all questionnaires, interview schedules, scales, surveys, and demographic questions, etc. in the Appendix.

A brief description of the purpose of the study is provided to the participants at the beginning of the study. Their consent to take part in the study is requested and collected.

Participants are provided with a brief of data being collected, how it will be used, and a privacy policy ahead of commencing data collection.

The participants are asked to perform the online survey once the consent was received.

The study is fully automated as well as progression paths capturing informed consent. It will not be possible for participants to commence the data gathering phase until informed consent is provided. Constructs will also be in place to prevent click through.

It is envisaged that the entire process will not take more than 20 minutes.

The survey to be answered by the participants and the consent request are provided in Appendix A and Appendix B respectively.

Part C: Ethical Risk

Please identify any ethical issues or risks of harm or distress which may arise during the proposed research, and how you will address this risk. Here you need to consider the potential for physical risk, social risk (i.e. loss of social status, privacy, or reputation), outside of that expected in everyday life, and whether the participant is likely to feel distress as a result of taking part in the study. Debriefing sheets must be included in the appendix if required. These should detail the participant's right to withdraw from the study, the statutory limits upon confidentiality, and the obligations of the researcher in relation to Freedom of Information legislation. Debriefing sheets should also include details of helplines and avenues for receiving support in the event that participants become distressed as a result of their involvement in this study.

It is not envisaged that there is any risk of harm or distress to participants.

Participants are allowed to withdraw from this study anytime if they wish to do so.

Do the participants belong to any of the following vulnerable groups?
(Please tick all those involved).

- ☐ Children;
- ☐ The older old (85+)
- ☐ People with an intellectual or learning disability
- ☐ Individuals or groups receiving help through the voluntary sector
- ☐ Those in a subordinate position to the researchers such as employees
- ☐ Other groups who might not understand the research and consent process
- ☐ Other vulnerable groups

How will the research participants in this study be selected, approached and recruited? From where will participants be recruited? If recruiting via an institution or organisation other than NCI please attach a letter of agreement from the host institution agreeing to host the study and circulate recruitment advertisements/email etc.

Amazon Mechanical Turk email system will be used to invite people to take part in this study. The participants are selected on a voluntary basis.

What inclusion or exclusion criteria will be used?

Participants must be at least 18 years old.

Participants must have an active Facebook account.

How will participants be informed of the nature of the study and participation?

An invitation email describing the study purpose and procedure will be sent to the invited participants.

Does the study involve deception or the withholding of information? If so, provide justification for this decision.

N/A

What procedures will be used to document the participants' consent to participate?

The study will be fully automated as well as progression paths capturing informed consent. It will not be possible for participants to commence the data gathering phase until informed consent was provided. Constructs will also be in place to prevent click through.

Can study participants withdraw at any time without penalty? If so, how will this be communicated to participants?

Yes. This will be communicated in the invitation email.

If vulnerable groups are participating, what special arrangements will be made to deal with issues of informed consent/assent?

N/A

Please include copies of any information letters, debriefing sheets, and consent forms with the application.

Part D: Confidentiality and Data Protection

Please indicate the form in which the data will be collected.

☐ Identified ☐ Potentially Identifiable ☒ De-Identified

What arrangements are in place to ensure that the identity of participants is protected?

One way hashing of identifiable information. Only processed anonymised information will be stored.

Will any information about illegal behaviours be collected as part of the research process? If so, detail your consideration of how this information will be treated.

No such information will be collected.

Please indicate any recording devices being used to collect data (e.g. audio/video).

No recording devices are used.

Please describe the procedures for securing specific permission for the use of these recording devices in advance.

N/A

Please indicate the form in which the data will be stored.

☐ Identified

☐ Potentially Identifiable

☐ De-Identified

Who will have responsibility for the data generated by the research?

The applicant for the Ethics approval.

Is there a possibility that the data will be archived for secondary data analysis? If so, has this been included in the informed consent process? Also include information on how and where the data will be stored for secondary analytic purposes.

No.

If not to be stored for secondary data analysis, will the data be stored for 5 years and then destroyed, in accordance with NCI policy?

☒ Yes

☐ No

Dissemination and Reporting

Please describe how the participants will be informed of dissemination and reporting (e.g. submission for examination, reporting, publications, presentations)?

The participants will not be informed about the project report.

If any dissemination entails the use of audio, video and/or photographic records (including direct quotes), please describe how participants will be informed of this in advance.

N/A

Part E: Signed Declaration

I confirm that I have read the NCI Ethical Guidelines for Research with Human Participants, and agree to abide by them in conducting this research. I also confirm that the information provided on this form is correct (Electronic signature is acceptable).

Signature of Applicant __Simon Caton

Date _____10/05/2015_____

Signature of Supervisor (where appropriate):

Date _____

Any other information the committee should be aware of?

N/A

APPENDIX A – SURVEY QUESTIONS

The survey questions are presented below.

Facebook Usage:

- SM1. How often do you log into Facebook?
- SM2. How often do you update your profile?
- SM3. How many Facebook friends do you have?
- SM4. Who are you interested in contacting on Facebook?
- SM5. What do you find yourself frequently “Liking”?
- SM6. Do you leave your contact information (Email, phone number, address) public on Facebook?
- SM7. Which information about yourself do you have available on Facebook?
- SM8. To which degree do you agree with this statement? “People should present themselves on online social networks as the same person as they are offline.”
- SM9. With which of the following statements do you agree? (Choose all that apply) I use Facebook ...
 - A. because contacting to others is simple
 - B. because I'm curious, about the kind of life of people I do not know
 - C. to be recognized by others

- D. because I can observe people around me
- E. to obtain support from others
- F. because I can learn a lot about others without me having to be seen
- G. to inform others what I'm doing
- H. to show everyone what I know and what I can
- I. because this is how people connect nowadays
- J. because I can reach many people
- K. to give something and, if necessary to get something back
- L. to show a different side of myself

SM10. Do other people present themselves differently in online and offline settings?

SM11. Complete the following statement. I manage my image on Facebook with (Choose all that apply)

- A. group memberships
- B. personal interests
- C. a profile picture that shows my face
- D. likes
- E. my Friend List
- F. a profile picture that is not obviously me
- G. Albums
- H. my Cover photo

SM12. Do you upload pictures to Facebook?

SM13. Other people represent themselves on Facebook by

- A. group memberships
- B. personal interests
- C. a profile picture that shows their face
- D. likes
- E. Friend List
- F. a profile picture that is not obviously them
- G. Albums
- H. Cover photo

SM14. To what extent do you agree with the following statements?

- A. I quickly understand how I am perceived by others.
- B. I can determine myself what I do or do not show others.
- C. I can show personality completely.
- D. I can be who or what I want on my Profile Page.
- E. I can be more open online than in real life.
- F. Online, I can present myself to everyone.

Human Flourishing Scale:

HF 1. *Competence*

Most days I feel a sense of accomplishment from what I do

HF 2. *Emotional stability*

(In the past week) I felt calm and peaceful

HF. 3 *Engagement*

I love learning new things

HF 4. *Meaning*

I generally feel that what I do in my life is valuable and worthwhile

HF 5. *Optimism*

I am always optimistic about my future

HF 6. *Positive emotion*

Taking all things together, how happy would you say you are?

HF 7. *Positive relationships*

There are people in my life who really care about me

HF 8. *Resilience*

When things go wrong in my life it generally takes me a long time to get back to normal.

HF 9. *Self-esteem*

In general, I feel very positive about myself

HF 10. *Vitality*

(In the past week) I had a lot of energy

APPENDIX B – CONSENT REQUEST

The consent declaration is presented below.

Principal Investigator: Dr. Simon Caton, Head, Young Investigator Group: Social Cloud; Karlsruhe Institute of Technology, Germany. simon.caton@kit.edu.

Advisor: *Prof. Dr. Christof Weinhardt, Institute for Information Management and Marketing, KIT, Germany*

Other Investigator(s): *Margeret Hall, Research Assistant, Karlsruhe Service Research Institute, hall@kit.edu*

1. Purpose of the Study: The purpose of this research is to investigate the phenomenon of self-representation in online social media. For this, we will access your Facebook timeline posts while you complete a short survey.

2. Procedures to be followed: You will be asked to answer a series of standard personality questions. In the meantime, the Facebook app will access your timeline posts. No additional actions must be taken.

3. Duration/Time:

The upper limit for this questionnaire is one hour. Participants generally finish the questionnaire within 20-25 minutes.

4. Statement of Confidentiality: Your participation in this research is confidential. Data is anonymized and stored offline; no personal data will be used in this research. Your confidentiality will be maintained to the degree permitted by the technology used. Specifically, no guarantees can be made regarding the interception of data sent via the Internet by any third parties. In the event of any publication or presentation resulting from the research, no personally identifiable information will be shared because your name is in no way linked to your responses.

5. Right to Ask Questions: Please contact *simon.caton@kit.edu* at with questions or concerns about this study. You have the right to request your data removed from this study at any time.

6. Payment for participation:

0.01 USD is awarded per response.

7. Voluntary Participation: Your decision to be in this research is voluntary. You can stop at any time. You do not have to answer any questions you do not want to answer.

By entering the questionnaire, you confirm that:

I am 18 years of age or older.

I AGREE to take part in this study.

Please print a copy of this form for your records or future reference.